

Programmatic Incompatibility: Ideology, Trust and the Limits of Rebel Cooperation Among Syria's Kurdish Actors

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Abstract

This article examines how ideology shapes alliance trajectories in multi-party civil wars, focusing on the Syrian Kurdish PYD and KNC. Challenging materialist explanations, I show that programmatic incompatibility and mutually exclusive designs for political order, creates an intractable commitment problem that overrides structural pressures to cooperate. Drawing on rebel leaders' interviews and document analysis, this research shows how ideology produced conflicting approaches to governance, alliances and threat perceptions, hindering cooperation between rebels. By specifying the causal mechanisms through which programmatic conflict produces systematic rule-breaking in formal pacts, the article provides a new framework for understanding alliance failure in civil wars.

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Introduction

Why do rebel groups fail to form durable alliances, even when facing a common existential threat? Rebel cooperation and fragmentation dynamics fundamentally shape conflict trajectories from conflict duration and civilian harm to post-conflict settlement prospects (e.g., Cunningham et al. 2012, Seymour 2014). While rationalist frameworks predict that material incentives and external threats should compel cooperation, they often relegate ideology to a secondary role. This article argues that programmatic ideological incompatibility, when rebel groups possess mutually exclusive blueprints for a future political order, creates an intractable commitment problem that overrides these pressures. In such contexts, institutionalised alliances are perceived as an existential threat, rendering defection the dominant strategy.

I test this theory through a mechanism-guided analysis of the Syrian Kurdish Democratic Union Party (PYD) and the Kurdish National Council (KNC) between 2011 and 2015. Although intra-Kurdish rivalry predates the Syrian conflict, dominant expectations in the civil war and rebel alliance literature hold that existential threats and pressure from shared external patrons and domestic constituencies should still generate at least tactical coordination. Why did the PYD and KNC fail to sustain even short-term cooperation despite the strong structural and political pressures to do so? Using elite interviews and documentary analysis, I trace this failure to the incompatibility between the PYD's programme of decentralised, multi-ethnic confederalism and the KNC's pursuit of a traditional ethno-national federation. This finding shows how ideology can operate as a binding constraint on strategic choice by specifying the causal mechanism that links programmatic conflict to persistent alliance failure, tracing how clashing political blueprints erode trust and undermine credible commitments.

Literature Review

Situating the PYD – KNC trajectory within civil wars scholarship reveals existing frameworks' limitations regarding rebel cooperation. While rationalist accounts suggest that the existential threats and external patronage should have compelled at least tactical coordination, constructivist and organisational theories offer competing explanations for why groups might remain apart. Rationalist, principal-agent and identity-based approaches offer partial insights but fail to fully explain Kurdish cooperation failure. In the rationalist paradigm, rebel cooperation is a product of rational calculations based on the distribution of power and the structure of material incentives (e.g., Bakke et al. 2012, pp. 274, 276, Cunningham et al. 2012, Fjelde and Nilsson 2012, pp. 607, 612). Fotini Christia (2012) argues that rebel groups are power maximisers forming tactical 'minimum winning coalitions' to maximise both their security and their share of post-conflict spoils. Weaker groups are compelled to balance against rising hegemons to avoid being eliminated in an anarchic environment with no third-party enforcement. Within this framework, identity and ideology are merely instrumental, post-hoc justifications elites use to mobilise followers. This logic of material incentives extends to external patrons in Principal-Agent models, which argue that a shared sponsor can enforce cooperation between untrusting rebel actors by credibly threatening to deny resources, thus rewarding loyalty and punishing defection (Popovic 2018, p. 758). However, the standard Principal-Agent model is insufficient for cases where the agent is not a pre-existing actor but an ideological and organisational offshoot of its patron.

Research on transnational insurgencies shows that organisational templates and governance blueprints travel across borders via transnational networks, propaganda, and training programmes, functioning as portable blueprints that groups imitate (Stewart 2021, pp. 13, 24, 72). In principal-agent relationships, sponsors often enforce these blueprints on their agents. Sara Plana identifies 'preference control' (ideological/ leadership alignment) as the most effective mode of proxy control, beyond mere resource leverage (Plana 2023, p. 222). Proxies replicate the institutional structures and ideological commitments of a parent movement, often governed by a principle of ideological exclusivity requiring that the patron's worldview be adopted without contamination (Sip 2025). Finally, when patrons act as mediators, the mediation literature suggests that such actors lack neutrality and instead use their leverage to advance their own and their client's interests, producing asymmetric leverage that undermines impartial brokerage (Svensson 2014, pp. 30–34).

Subsequent scholarship identified specific conditions that alter these rational calculations, such as shifts in the balance of power creating windows of opportunity or vulnerability that incentivise fratricide (Pischedda 2018, p. 90).¹ Regine Schwab (2023, pp. 1008–1011) argues that the level of 'military constraint' from a shared enemy determines inter-rebel strategy: high constraint compels cooperation by raising the costs of infighting, while low constraint permits fratricide. Similarly, large-N models test for 'tacit coalitions', which emerge from calculations of 'military synergies' (benefits derived from geographic proximity or ethnic ties) and preferences for power-balanced partnerships to mitigate the risks of post-victory infighting. However, by 'leaving aside ideology' to focus on material factors (Steinwand and Metternich 2022, p. 3), they struggle to explain why some alliances fail to institutionalise even when material incentives are aligned.

Another body of research focuses on ascriptive characteristics, such as identity, arguing instead that identity proximity can be a primary driver of conflict. Quantitative studies find that co-ethnic groups are more likely to engage in violent rivalry, as they are locked in a zero-sum competition for the same constituency of recruits, resources, and popular support (Conrad et al. 2021, p. 124). This validates the micro-level mechanism of 'resource cumulativeness', where the victor can more easily absorb a defeated co-ethnic rival's resource base, creating an incentive for fratricide (Pischedda 2018, p. 147). More recently, this logic has been extended to ideology itself. Mohammad-Ali Tabaar (2025, pp. 1, 3–4) shows that ideologically proximate groups become intense rivals by competing for the same 'market' of legitimacy. They exploit the common ideology to attack each other's 'authenticity', leading to a dynamic of 'violent outbidding'. This dynamic explains intra-ideological competition amongst Syrian Islamist factions: Jabhat al-Nusra and Ahrar al-Sham

shifted from cooperation to conflict over local governance, despite their shared Salafi-jihadist orientation (Berti 2020, pp. 9–10). These studies thus show that characteristics often assumed to foster rebel unity, such as shared ethnicity or ideology, can instead become arenas for intractable competition, confirming broader work on nationalist movements, where intra-movement rivalry and competing claims to authentic representation are the norm rather than the exception (Cederman and Girardin 2007, Fliervoet and Seymour 2023).

Conversely, substantial evidence shows that ideational and relational factors are often primary drivers of durable cooperation. In Syria, Tire Gade et al. (2019, pp. 2071, 2074, 2084) find ‘ideological homophily’,² particularly a shared vision for the future state, is a more powerful predictor of alliance than material incentives or external sponsors. Large-N studies as well show that shared ideology increases the durability of alliances, especially under intense state repression (Blair et al. 2022, pp. 1, 26). Relational ties, including shared identities, are crucial for forming institutionalised ‘united fronts’ rather than shallow ‘battlefield coordination’ (Topal 2024, pp. 7–10). Indeed, shared ideology has a stronger positive effect on formal alliances than shared ethnicity, which is often plagued by high levels of distrust (Balcells et al. 2022, pp. 6, 11). Correspondingly, ideologically heterogeneous alliances are more likely to break down (Corradi 2023, p. 257). Together, this body of work establishes the causal importance of ideational factors, establishing that shared worldviews and social ties play a central role in explaining the most committed forms of rebel cooperation.

This literature thus reaches a central theoretical impasse. Structural theories of ‘military constraint’ predict that an existential threat should compel cooperation for survival (Schwab 2023, pp. 1010–1011), while theories of co-ethnic competition correctly anticipate a baseline of intense rivalry (Conrad et al. 2021, pp. 760–761, 768). At the same time, relational theories suggest a shared ethnic identity should provide the very ‘channels of trust’ needed to overcome such rivalry and forge a durable pact (Blair et al. 2022, p. 36, Topal 2024, p. 3). The inability of these frameworks to adjudicate these competing predictions points to a deeper puzzle: why does formal, institutionalised cooperation repeatedly collapse even when material incentives are high and a basis for relational trust appears to exist? The next section develops a mechanism-centred theoretical framework for this pattern of persistent alliance failure.

Theoretical Framework

To resolve this puzzle, I advance a theory of programmatic ideological incompatibility. I argue that the failure of rebel alliances stems not from material incentives or simple ethnic rivalry, but from an intractable commitment problem rooted in mutually exclusive political blueprints. It is the content of these blueprints that determines whether shared identity generates trust or rivalry, thus specifying the micro-foundations of alliance failure. In specifying this mechanism, this paper answers the field’s call to move beyond broad correlations (Larson 2021, p. 104) by connecting the relational nature of conflict (Podder 2018) to the collision between competing ‘supralocal’ political projects and ‘local’ power realities (Desgrais et al. 2018, p. 657). This section defines core concepts, specifies the three-channel causal mechanism, and derives empirical expectations.

Conceptual Foundations

First, the independent variable is programmatic ideology. Following Francisco Sanin and Elisabeth Wood (2014) and Jonathan Leader Maynard (2019), ideology is a worldview that constitutes actors’ interests, defines political goals, and shapes strategic choices. A programmatic ideology is a structured form that offers a detailed governance ‘blueprint’ (Sanin and Wood 2014, p. 214). Programmatic incompatibility exists where two groups’ political blueprints are mutually exclusive, such that no stable alliance can satisfy both simultaneously. Unlike ideological distance, which locates actors along continuums such as left-right or

Islamist-secular, it captures cases where parties are close on rhetoric yet incompatible on institutional design. To operationalise programmatic incompatibility, I adapt Gade et al.'s (2019, p. 2074) framework to focus on the institutional dimensions central to political bargaining. A group's programme is defined by its concrete answers to three fundamental questions: (1) The Ideal Polity: What is the desired institutional structure of the state (e.g., a decentralised, multi-ethnic confederal system vs. a centralised ethnic federation)? (2) The Political Community: Who are the legitimate members of this polity (e.g., an inclusive citizenry vs. a community defined by a single ethno-national identity)? (3) Strategic Imperatives: Based on the above, who are the primary enemies and acceptable allies? This dictates core strategic red lines and partnership choices.

Such programmatic commitment, where ideology dictates institutional and strategic choices, is well-documented in civil conflicts.³ Here, the programmatic ideologies of the PYD and KNC are treated as a direct product of constitutive patronage: they are not primarily indigenous political projects but are substantially inherited from their respective patron movements, the Kurdistan Workers' Party (PKK)⁴ and the Kurdistan Democratic Party (KDP),⁵ through the mechanisms of doctrinal diffusion and organisational mimesis described in the literature. The rigidity of these programmes is therefore reinforced by the principle of ideological exclusivity, making their core tenets non-negotiable without risking a rupture of the foundational political bond that underpins each proxy's identity and legitimacy.

Second, the dependent variable, alliance failure, is defined by the depth of cooperation. Adopting Sedef A. Topal's (2024, pp. 7–8) distinction, this article differentiates between shallow 'battlefield coordination' and deep, institutionalised 'united fronts'. Alliance failure is therefore defined as the inability to transition from shallow coordination to an institutionalised united front. Empirically, failure is coded when (a) no joint command or governance body with decision-making authority is sustained, and/or (b) written integration clauses are systematically missed or reversed.

Finally, this theory posits that programmatic incompatibility generates an intractable commitment problem (Fearon 1995, Walter 1997). When groups hold mutually exclusive political blueprints, any institutionalised agreement is perceived not as a compromise, but as a stepping stone towards an opponent's victory. The bargaining process itself is transformed into an existential threat, making defection the dominant strategy. The next section specifies the precise causal pathways through which this occurs.

The Causal Mechanism: How Programmatic Incompatibility Drives Cooperation Failure

Programmatic incompatibility drives failure through three mutually reinforcing channels.

(1) Channel 1: Divergent Interpretation of the Strategic Environment.

Programmatic commitments function as an interpretive filter. A group's programme dictates its choice of tactics (Asal et al. 2013, pp. 307, 314), its desired model of social order (Pfeifer and Schwab 2023, p. 6), and its rules on internal compliance (Scharpf 2018, p. 208). When these filters diverge, groups systematically prioritise different goals, perceive threats differently and advocate for distinct strategies even when facing a common enemy (Straus 2012, p. 549, Worrall 2017, p. 717). This interpretive divergence feeds directly into the commitment problem by hardening beliefs about a potential partner's opportunism and lowering trust ex ante. (2) Channel 2: Erosion of Trust and the Failure of Institutional Design. This interpretive divergence erodes inter-group trust, the central mediating variable between ideology and the ability to solve the commitment problem. I treat trust as a rational expectation of compliance with jointly specified rules, observed through formalisation, follow-through on commitments, and other credible signals. Where programmatic differences are large, the relational overlaps that build trust are weak or absent (Balcells et al. 2022, p. 7, Topal 2024, pp. 6–12). Consistent with network-centred accounts, the lack of a shared worldview makes defection fears salient and enforcement difficult, pushing alliances towards shallow bargains that unravel when constraints loosen (Staniland 2014, ch. 1, Parkinson 2013).

(3) Channel 3: Constitutive Patronage, Biased Mediation, and the Limits of Transactional Sponsorship. This mechanism refines the concept of external influence by distinguishing between three distinct third-party roles observable in the Syrian Kurdish case: the Patron, the Mediator and the Sponsor. A Patron (e.g., the PKK, the KDP) is a parent organisation that provides the proxy with its foundational programmatic ideology through doctrinal diffusion. The patron's influence is constitutive, setting the non-negotiable ideological red lines of the conflict. A Mediator is an actor attempting to broker an agreement. In this case, the primary mediator (the KDP) was also a patron, creating a dynamic of biased mediation characterised by asymmetric leverage (Svensson 2014, pp. 7, 31, 34). It possessed high credibility and relational leverage with its own proxy (the KNC) but only coercive or material leverage with the opposing proxy (the PYD), making a trust-based, procedurally fair outcome structurally impossible. A Sponsor (e.g., the United States) is a third party that provides transactional, often material, support to achieve a limited strategic objective, such as counter-terrorism.

Methodology

This study employs a qualitative, mechanism-guided analysis of the failed PYD-KNC cooperation. I disaggregate the case into four episodes, the 'constituent parts' of the process (Beach and Pedersen 2019, p. 38). This segmentation traces the 'productive continuity' (Beach and Pedersen 2019, p. 70) of causal force from programmatic incompatibility to trust erosion. Each episode's boundaries were defined by institutional turning points that facilitate a 'cascading comparison' (Lyll 2015, p. 197) of the mechanism under varying conditions. Episode 1 establishes the ex ante programmatic divergence following the Syrian uprising; Episode 2 examines why the power-sharing institutions of the Erbil Agreement collapsed; Episode 3 analyzes the final breakdown of joint bodies and the PYD's unilateral imposition of the Social Contract; and Episode 4 tests whether US pressure and the ISIS threat could override these divisions via the Duhok Agreement (see Table 1). The analysis concludes in 2015: with the International Coalition supporting the Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF) alliance model and deprioritizing KNC integration, the structural incentives driving the research puzzle ceased to apply, rendering further analysis 'needlessly cumulative' (Beach and Pedersen 2019, p. 230).

Table 1. Theory-driven empirical expectations.

Expectation	Core Claim	Evidence for (supports mechanism)	Counterevidence (would falsify)
E1 – Divergent Interpretations	Programmatic incompatibility shapes threat perception, allies/enemies, sequencing, and red lines	Leaders' statements and rejected agreements reveal persistent disagreements over strategic priorities, acceptable allies, sequencing, and red lines	Demonstrated convergence on these four items over time: records of joint planning overriding earlier differences
E2 – Trust & Institutional Commitments	Greater ideological distance → shallow, ad hoc cooperation	Written integration clauses (joint command, detainees) systematically missed/reversed; leaders explicitly signal distrust	Durable, jointly enforced institutions persisting despite ideological distance; absence of distrust-signalling prior to breakdown
E3 – External Shocks	Sponsors enforce tactical alignment but cannot generate durable pacts	Sponsor actions followed by short-term cooperation without improved trust (as measured by E2 indicators)	Sponsor interventions leading to lasting institutions accompanied by increased trust

Table 2. List of leaders and experts interviewed.

Name	Role	Interview Date and Location
Mahmod Ahmad Arbo	Politician, KNC committee member	December 2022, Erbil (Iraq)
Abdulhakim Bachar	Politician, first president of the KNC	December 2022, Erbil
Anonymous	Local Academic	January 2023, Erbil
Ibrahim Biro	Politician, president of the KNC (2015–17)	January 2023, Erbil
Salih Muslim	Politician, Co-chair of the PYD	June 2023, online
Sanharip Barsom	Politician, Co-chair of the SUP	July 2023, online

Primary data consists of semi-structured interviews with key actors directly involved in the PYD – KNC negotiations or with expert knowledge of Syrian Kurdish politics (see Table 2). Selection was purposive and elite-centred, requiring formal leadership responsibility in PYD – KNC bargaining. Three interviews were conducted with KNC representatives in Erbil, Iraq (December 2022 – January 2023), two online with the PYD and the Syriac Union Party (SUP) co-chairs, and one with a local academic in Erbil, anonymised for confidentiality (January 2023). All interviews were recorded and transcribed with prior informed consent. Fieldwork was approved by the University of Milan’s Ethics Committee (opinion n° 113/22).⁶ Moreover, the study analyses the Erbil/Hawlêr Agreement (2012) and the Duhok Agreement (2014) between the PYD and KNC, obtained from public repositories and KNC representatives. These provide the institutional design against which implementation claims are assessed. Finally, academic articles, think-tank and NGO reports and news articles are used to date events, contextualise agreements and corroborate interview claims. Preference is given to contemporaneous material with transparent sourcing.

Analytical Strategy

The analysis proceeds abductively and is mechanism guided. I read the interviews and documents iteratively, keeping analytic memos and a chronology – mechanism matrix (see Appendix A1) aligned to the three channels specified in the theory:

- Interpretation (Mechanism 1): recurrent divergences in how leaders define threats, priorities, and acceptable partners/end-states.
- Trust and commitments (Mechanism 2): the form of cooperation (informal vs. institutionalised) and implementation reliability (missed steps, reversals) measured against what the agreements stipulate.
- External sponsorship (Mechanism 3): signals from the United States and KRG/KDP (facilitation, vetoes, or conditionality) that plausibly alter incentives but cannot substitute for trust.

Reliance on elite interviews risks recall bias and strategic framing by participants.⁷ To mitigate this, I triangulated claims with contemporaneous documents and reports, cross-checked opposing accounts and focused on actors’ stated reasons for their decisions as direct evidence of the ‘interpretive filter’ mechanism rather than objective history. Where accounts diverged, I reported both and prioritised dated texts (agreement clauses, communiqués, news reports) for sequencing (see Table 3 and 4). As the research question targets leadership-level bargains, findings concern elite decision mechanisms.

Table 3. Illustration of the study’s evidence operationalisation. For each mechanism, it specifies what is being tested, evidentiary anchors used for triangulation, examples from the data, and the resulting analytical judgement.

Mechanism	What was tested	How (anchor)	Evidence (examples)	Judgement
M1: Interpretation (E1)	Do the PYD and KNC maintain incompatible answers to core programmatic questions (Ideal Polity, Strategic Partners, Sequencing, Red Lines)?	Compare foundational charters, draft agreements, and principals’ public and private statements.	KNC: Goal is an ethno-national federation via alignment with the Syrian National Council (SNC). ‘We [KNC] ask only for the rights of the Kurdish people’. (Bachar, Dec 2022) PYD: Goal is a decentralised, multi-ethnic ‘Third Way’ via local governance-first. The Social Contract is ‘pluralist, rights based’. (Barsom, Jul 2023)	Divergence Stable. Incompatible programs are articulated early and persist across all episodes.
M2: Trust & Commitments (E2)	Did the parties implement specific, written institutional clauses in formal agreements (Erbil, Duhok)?	Compare formal agreement texts against the documented record of implementation (or non-implementation).	KNC Claim: Erbil/Duhok failed due to PYD unilateralism, e.g., security integration of Rojava Peshmerga was consistently blocked. ‘If power [was] shared’, integration was possible. (Interview, Dec 2022) PYD Action: Unilaterally adopted the Social Contract (Jan 2014), superseding the joint-design principle of the Erbil agreement.	Systematic Failure. Redistributive clauses (power-sharing, security) consistently fail, while specific, crisis-driven clauses (Kobani defence) are implemented. Written pacts serve as the yardstick for measuring defection.

Table 4. Process-tracing evidence of programmatic incompatibility and alliance failure.

Episode & Key Events	Mechanism 1: Divergent Strategic Interpretations	Mechanism 2: Weaker Commitments & Lower Trust	Mechanism 3: External Pressure as a Substitute for Trust
1. Early Positioning (2011–12)	Priorities: Local self-rule (PYD) vs. national-level recognition (KNC). Partners: Multi-ethnic coalition (PYD) vs. SNC-alignment (KNC). Sequencing: Governance-first (PYD) vs. joint-design-first (KNC).	N/A (No formal agreement to test). Baseline distrust established by rival programmatic choices.	KRG sponsorship of KNC and PKK-PYD connection establishes competing external poles from the outset.
2. Erbil Agreement (2012–13)	Mutually exclusive interpretations of the Rojava Peshmerga's status as either a joint security asset or a rival army.	Shallow Cooperation: Joint Committee (DBK) stalls. Clause Failure: Security and media détente pledges are violated (e.g., Amûdê killings). Unilateral Reversal: Border management committee is unilaterally dissolved.	KRG mediation successfully convenes parties but fails to enforce vague, redistributive clauses, demonstrating the limits of non-binding sponsorship.
3. Drift & Unilateralism (2013–14)	PYD interprets KNC's diplomatic strategy as complicity with hostile actors; KNC interprets PYD's local rule as illegitimate.	Formal Defection: PYD unilaterally adopts the Social Contract, creating a formal institution outside the joint framework. Systematic Non-Compliance: Disputes over elections and conscription show a complete breakdown of prior commitments.	Mediation efforts are tactical and unable to prevent unilateral institutionalisation, showing external influence cannot substitute for the missing foundation of trust.
4. Duhok Agreement & collapse (2014–2015)	PYD leadership's public statements interpret 'power-sharing' as KNC 'participation' in its existing administration and security integration as unilateral absorption into the YPG.	Bifurcated Implementation: Specific military clauses implemented; institutional power-sharing fails immediately. Explicit Distrust: KNC leaders frame the process as an attempt at 'hostile absorption'.	Contingent Enforcement: US/KRG pressure enforces temporary battlefield cooperation (Kobani) but fails to build political trust; US shift to SDF model removes pressure for KNC integration.

Case Study Analysis

The Syrian Uprising and the Kurdish Question

Understanding Syrian Kurdish dynamics at the revolution's onset requires considering decades of intra-Kurdish rivalries and hostility towards the Syrian state. Successive Baathist governments, from Hafez al-Assad to his son Bashar, denied Syria's Kurds, an estimated 10–15 per cent of the population mostly concentrated in three non-contiguous northern enclaves,⁸ recognition as a national group, enforcing policies of repression rooted in the 1962 census that stripped nearly 120,000 of their citizenship and maintained strict limits on language, culture, and political organisation (Tejel 2009, pp. 50–65). From the 1980s until 1998, Damascus maintained a strategic alliance with the PKK, offering it a 'safe haven' for its insurgency against Turkey (Tejel 2018, p. 373). The regime used the PKK as leverage against Ankara regarding longstanding bilateral disputes⁹ (Gunter 2014, p. 54), while the PKK leadership suppressed a distinct Syrian Kurdish movement to preserve this pact (Kaya and Lowe 2017, p. 280). The alliance collapsed in 1998 under Turkish military pressure formalised in the Adana Agreement, which led to PKK leader Abdullah Öcalan's expulsion from Syria (Al-Kati 2019, p. 52). After Öcalan's capture in 1999, the PKK adopted a new strategy by creating ideologically aligned but formally independent parties in neighbouring countries, including the Democratic Union Party (PYD) in Syria in 2003 (Tejel 2009, p. 110). A second pivotal event was the 2004 Qamishli Uprising, which began as a riot at a Football match and rapidly escalated into unprecedented demonstrations and anti-regime rallies across all Kurdish regions of Syria (KurdWatch 2009, p. 4, Tejel 2018, p. 375). Protesters attacked symbols of state authority, and security forces crushed the protests with 'unusual harshness', killing protesters and arresting thousands (KurdWatch 2009, pp. 4, 10). Although Kurdish parties did not lead the protest and urged calm (KurdWatch 2009, p. 14), the crackdown reinforced Kurdish persecution narratives (KurdWatch 2009, p. 16) and the 'sobering lesson' that armed self-defence was essential (van Wilgenburg and Fumerton 2024, p. 1093). The 2011 Syrian uprising, described as a 'semi-sectarian civil war' (Phillips 2015, p. 371) and characterised by increasing mobilisation along ethno-sectarian lines (Baczko et al. 2017), presented Syrian Kurds with an opportunity to pursue long-denied self-determination.

Rise of the PYD

The Democratic Union Party (PYD), founded in 2003, emerged as a significant force among Syrian Kurds, particularly in the Afrin and Kobane regions (Tejel 2020). The PYD is a strict adherent to 'Apoism', the post-Marxist, libertarian socialist philosophy of imprisoned PKK leader Abdullah Öcalan (Plakoudas 2017, pp. 103–104). This foundation defined the PYD's ideal polity by emphasising grassroots democracy, multi-ethnic inclusivity, feminism and a cooperative economy (Novellis 2018, p. 116) and positioning the PYD as the Syrian vanguard of the 'post-Marxist revolutionary pole' of Kurdish politics (Grojean 2018, p. 265). Although its connection to the PKK long established networks allowed the PYD to become the most organised Kurdish party by 2011 (Tejel 2020), it also became a major source of contention (Pollock 2012). The PYD pursued a tactical neutrality with the regime, the so called 'third way', to create the space for its own local governance project, a strategy fundamentally at odds with the KNC's objectives (Hossino and Tanir 2012, p. 12, Sidki 2012, p. 2). This strategy was enforced through both coercion and institution-building. Throughout early 2012, PYD supporters attacked anti-regime demonstrations organised by other Kurdish parties, with chants explicitly targeting their opponents' external affiliations: 'supporters of Erdogan and Barzani have no business here' (Hossino and Tanir 2012, p. 13). Moreover, the PYD established its armed wings: the People's Protection Units (YPG) and the all-female Women's Protection Unit (YPJ), made significantly more effective by veteran PKK cadres (Plakoudas 2017, pp. 102–103, Tejel 2018, p. 376) and created to fill the security vacuum left by withdrawing regime forces. As a consequence, the Syrian opposition accused the PYD of collaborating with the regime, a tension that erupted into armed clashes between YPG and Free Syrian Army units in border towns like Ras al-Ain (Al Arabiya with AFP 2012, International Crisis Group 2013). This choice

positioned the PYD in a rival bloc to the KNC and its alignment with the Turkish-and Western-backed SNC.

The Formation of the KNC

The Kurdish National Council (KNC) was established in October 2011 as a coalition of 16 Syrian Kurdish nationalist parties united under the sponsorship of Iraqi Kurdish leader Masoud Barzani.¹⁰ The KNC was positioned as the primary political counterweight to the PYD (Hevian 2013, p. 46). Its foundational charter defined its ideal polity as a federal state that would constitutionally recognise the Kurds' 'right to self-determination within a still-existing Syrian nation-state'. Its core strategic imperative was to act as 'part of the nationwide Syrian opposition' (KurdWatch 2012a). This platform, rooted in a traditional ethno-nationalist vision of federal autonomy, prioritised the designation 'Syrian Kurdistan' (Kurdistana Sûriyê) to conceptualise the region as a bounded ethnic territory awaiting state recognition (McGee 2022, pp. 387–88), and represented the 'conservative, liberal pole' of Kurdish nationalism, deeply intertwined with the KDP (Grojean 2018, p. 265). Lacking its own military force after the PYD blocked its KDP-trained 'Rojava Peshmerga' (van Wilgenburg and Fumerton 2024, p. 1094), the KNC pursued a purely diplomatic strategy by aligning with the Syrian National Council, the Western-backed Syrian opposition. The KNC saw the PYD's 'third way' and governance project as a betrayal of both the Kurdish cause and the Syrian revolution (van Wilgenburg and Fumerton 2024, p. 1095). The KNC's formation thus crystallised the conflict's central dynamic: a clash between two mutually exclusive political programmes.

Episode 1 — Uprising & Early Positioning (2011–Mid-2012)

Syria's Kurdish parties' response to the 2011 uprising showed their programmatic differences, revealing a foundational interpretive gap (E1) in how they interpreted the window of opportunity provided by the uprising. Initially, Kurdish parties adopted a 'wait-and-see strategy' (Tejel 2018, p. 375). Twelve parties, including the PYD and those that later formed the KNC, launched the 'Initiative of the National Movement' in May 2011. This platform demanded a 'just solution' to the Kurdish issue through constitutional recognition, linguistic and cultural rights and the establishment of a democratic, pluralistic Syria (Kajjo and Sinclair 2011). However, this apparent consensus masked deep programmatic divisions. While both the PYD and the KNC member parties had some level of popular support, the PYD's established organisational structure provided a significant advantage in consolidating control as the Syrian state weakened (Schmidinger 2018, pp. 86–93). The PYD had already declared the uprising 'not "their own" revolution' (Tejel 2018, p. 376) and began suppressing pro-revolution demonstrations in Kurdish areas (Sidki 2012, pp. 1–2) claiming it wanted to protect Kurdish regions from the violence engulfing other parts of Syria.¹¹ Instead, the parties that would form the KNC 'wanted to be an effective part of the demonstrations as soon as possible'¹² and 'organized protests against the regime, but the PYD organized protests against our protests'.¹³ Therefore, the May 2011 'Initiative' was less a unified platform than a temporary intersection of diverging paths. The initial gap in programmatic priorities and acceptable tactics between these two camps would ultimately define and derail all subsequent attempts at a united front.

This initial clash was the violent manifestation of two mutually exclusive political blueprints. The KNC's programme, rooted in the ethnonationalism of its patron's organisation, defined its ideal polity as a 'federalist Syria on the model of Iraqi Kurdistan'.¹⁴ This project was explicitly ethno-centric, designed to secure 'only the rights of Kurdish people'.¹⁵ In contrast, the PYD implemented the post-nationalist, revolutionary programme of its patron, the PKK, transforming 'Rojava' from a mere cartographic descriptor into a 'value-based' political space defined by radical democracy and women's liberation rather than ethnic borders (McGee 2022, p. 393). The PYD's democratic confederalist vision encompassed the entire region 'to solve the problems of all Syria, Turkey and Iraq, not for the Kurds'.¹⁶ Its goal, as co-chair Salih Muslim explained, was a decentralised, 'democratic state . . . which everybody can share living together'.¹⁷ These were not mere policy preferences but comprehensive worldviews that functioned as powerful interpretive filters (E1). Consequently, the KNC leadership interpreted the PYD's multi-ethnic project as an existential betrayal. Mahmud Arbor dismissed the PYD's programme of

‘seeking the brotherhood among many nationalities’ as ‘communist . . . utopian . . . against the nationalist mentality, against the Kurdish nation’, concluding its goal was ‘not to have an autonomous state for the Kurds’.¹⁸ This fundamental ideological chasm immediately produced divergent strategic imperatives that would prove crippling.

The effect of ideology as a binding constraint on strategic choice was evident in the parties’ opposing alliance strategies. The KNC’s ethno-nationalist federalist programme compelled it to seek legitimacy within the mainstream Syrian opposition, leading it into a strategic trap. Its chosen partner, the Syrian National Council (SNC), refused to discuss anything more than ‘administrative decentralization’ (Carnegie Middle East Center 2012), its chair Burhan Ghalioun declared that ‘federalism is not on the SNC agenda’ (Ghalioun 2012) and a ‘delusion’ (Daher 2016). The SNC, dominated by Arab nationalist and Islamist groups (Baczko et al. 2017, pp. 147–148) hesitated to acknowledge Kurdish demands, fearing it would lead to Syria’s fragmentation (Pollock 2012). The KNC was forced to remove from its charter demands for decentralisation to reach an agreement with the opposition (Kurd Net 2012). On the other hand, the PYD defined its political community not by ethnicity but by alignment to the third way, opening the alliance to all groups who ‘didn’t contaminate themselves with the Islamist groups’¹⁹ and attracting non-Kurdish allies such as the Arab Shammar tribe and Christian parties who were repelled by the opposition’s nationalism. For instance, the Syriac Union Party (SUP) rejected the SNC’s ‘chauvinistic and extremist traits . . . controlled by the Muslim Brotherhood’, endorsing the PYD’s project precisely because ‘in it we found a way of thinking that expresses our goals . . . this political project was the best suited for us as Syriacs and as Christians’.²⁰ The alliances allowed the PYD’s consolidation of control, especially over the Jazira region, and ‘prompted the need to adapt the [governance] system to better incorporate non-Kurdish [. . .] populations’ (Allsopp and van Wilgenburg 2019, p. 123). The KNC perceived the coalition as a mere alliance of convenience, arguing that ‘[the PYD] used these forces [Arab tribes, minorities] only to their own advantage. To show that they are a democratic force’.²¹ Therefore, the two camps entered the conflict with irreconcilable answers to the foundational questions of political order (E1): the PYD prioritised immediate local self-rule with multi-ethnic partners, while the KNC prioritised national-level recognition within a post-Assad federal Syria. This structural gap was rooted in fundamentally different worldviews. The PYD’s commitment to democratic confederalism led it to view the Syrian opposition as an unreliable ally due to a clash between the opposition’s centralised nationalism and the PYD’s vision of decentralised governance. As a result, the PYD prioritised autonomy over cooperation. In contrast, the KNC, aiming for international legitimacy, saw engagement with the opposition as its best path forward. This initial, stable interpretive gap made every subsequent attempt at power-sharing, as the following sections will demonstrate, an exercise in managing an already intractable commitment problem.

Episode 2 — Erbil/Hawlêr Agreement I (2012)

In 2012, as regime control weakened, the PYD declared self-governance in Kurdish-majority areas, consolidating authority over territory, resources and population. Control of border revenues, including taxation, and the creation of the People’s Council of Western Kurdistan (PCWK) and the Movement for a Democratic Society (TEV-DEM) institutionalised its rule (Lowe 2014, p. 228). At the same time, the Syrian opposition was gaining ground against Assad, and as clashes with Syrian rebels intensified, the YPG positioned itself as the primary protector of Kurdish communities, enhancing both dominance and legitimacy (International Crisis Group 2014, pp. 6–7). In this context, the June 2012 Hawlêr/Erbil Agreement represented the first attempt to manage the PYD – KNC rivalry, making its collapse a test of how programmatic distance undermines institutional bargains (E2). Brokered by the Iraqi Kurdish leadership to ‘prevent intra-Kurdish tensions’ (Al-Tamimi 2012), Barzani ‘wanted to avoid a possible war between Kurds’.²² The pact called for a ‘joint Supreme Committee of both councils to coordinate political and diplomatic work as well as to develop a unified political objective’, required parties to ‘Cease all propaganda activities’ and ‘Abolish all forms of armed presence in the Kurdish regions and communities’, and mandated ‘joint, unarmed protection committees’ with the disbanding of ‘all armed manifestations in the Kurdish areas and cities’ (KurdWatch 2012b). Yet it was vague on core issues of

power-sharing, the role of the YPG and military integration, external influence, and offered no enforcement mechanisms. Appendix B provides a detailed analysis of the agreement and its outcomes.

Each side interpreted the pact through opposing programmatic filters (E1). For the KNC, it was a lopsided deal signed ‘in favour of PYD’ signed only to ‘avoid any Kurdish-Kurdish conflict’ (Weiss 2012). Pro-PYD outlets instead hailed it as a revolutionary achievement ‘uniting Kurds of Syria’ with the goal to ‘overthrow the Baath regime’ (ANF News 2012a). This different framing shows that the agreement lacked a shared understanding of its own purpose, establishing it as a weak foundation for cooperation from the outset. Observers described it as a “‘marriage . . . of convenience” where “neither side trusts the other”” (International Crisis Group 2013, p. iii). However, in the short term the agreement successfully ensured ‘de facto Kurdish control of a large swathe of Syria’s north-east and the placing of this area off limits to the insurgency against the Assad regime’ (Al-Tamimi 2012, quoting Spyer). The agreement’s emphasis on general principles without actionable steps allowed the PYD flexibility in implementation. For example, the agreement’s call for ‘the overthrow of the dictatorship in Damascus, the construction of a democratic, pluralistic state, and the creation of a new Syria with many ethnicities’ (Erbil Agreement, 2012) was a broad goal that both parties could agree on rhetorically but did not commit either to concrete actions. The central test was the status of the YPG and the KNC-aligned Rojava Peshmerga, where programmatic incompatibility (E1) crystallised as an unsolvable commitment problem (E2). Ibrahim Biro recalled: ‘The PYD deliberately made the agreement vague and unenforceable to maintain [military] control’.²³ Barzani confirmed he was training Rojava Peshmerga to be deployed in Syria to fill ‘security vacuums’ under the Joint Committee (ANF News 2012b), while the PYD, alarmed by growing KNC – Turkey ties (Syria Direct 2020), insisted on absorption into the YPG. For the KNC, the force was a security guarantee and its only leverage; for the PYD, a rival army trained by a hostile patron. Bachar argued that integration was possible only if ‘power [was] shared’ and there was joint ‘leadership of [military] force’.²⁴ The PYD refused, demanding full absorption. Leaders on both sides admitted compromise was impossible, warning that the other’s entry would ‘provoke a clash’ (International Crisis Group 2013, pp. 25, 28). The failure to resolve this security dilemma, rooted in two mutually exclusive visions of the state’s monopoly on violence, became the clearest indicator of the agreement’s collapse.

Thus, instead of generating trust, the agreement produced its opposite: open public declarations which themselves serve as direct evidence of the deep distrust between the parties [E2]. The KNC leadership perceived systematic non-compliance by the PYD on any issue requiring genuine power-sharing, a conviction substantiated in their minds by perceived unilateral actions in security and administrative matters. KNC leaders cited specific examples to illustrate this perception. First, Bachar recounted an incident where a senior KNC official was allegedly unable to secure the release of his own nephew through the joint committee, forcing a personal appeal to PYD leader Aldar Xelil.²⁵ Second, Mahmod Arbo described a similar dynamic in the administrative sphere, claiming a joint border committee was unilaterally dissolved by Xelil, who ‘did not attribute any responsibility to the High Committee’.²⁶ Although it was not possible to independently confirm these episodes, they reveal the KNC’s deeply held conviction that the PYD was not a partner in power-sharing but a dominant actor consistently overriding any joint institution that constrained its authority. Bachar charged that ‘the PYD is still applying its own policies . . . through its . . . Armed Forces’ (Weiss 2012). They denounced the PYD’s governance as a sham, declaring ‘no areas have been liberated in Syrian Kurdistan’ from the regime (Weiss 2012). PYD-aligned groups replied furiously, accusing the KNC of ‘betrayal’ and ‘treacherous and counter revolutionary statements’ that violated the ‘Hewler agreement’, insisting that Syrian Kurdistan had been ‘peacefully liberated and democratically governed’ (ANF News 2012c). For the KNC, the agreement’s collapse reflected PKK ideology and PYD untrustworthiness: ‘If we study the history of the PKK, it has not respected its agreements with any Kurdish force. It signed treaties only for its own advantage and when it was weak’.²⁷ For the PYD, the KNC was a proxy: Muslim claimed the KNC withdrew from the agreement after ‘[Turkish Foreign Minister] Davutoglu . . . came to Erbil . . . and said openly, we are refusing this agreement’.²⁸ The failure of the Erbil Agreement provides a clear illustration of the paper’s

second mechanism (E2): ideological distance breeds a low-trust environment where written bargains remain shallow and unenforceable, especially when patrons' strategic priorities diverge (E3).

Episode 3 — Drift, Repression, PYD Governance Institutionalisation (2013–Mid-2014)

The period following the Erbil Agreement was characterised by a breach of commitment that made future trust-based cooperation impossible. While the Kurdish Supreme Committee continued its meetings, it was politically paralysed and by mid-2013 it was clear it had 'failed to unite Syria's quarrelling Kurdish groups' (Rudaw 2013a, 2013b). The point of no return was the Amûdê events of June 2013, when the YPG 'used excessive force against anti-PYD demonstrators' and, after coming 'under fire from people in the crowd, killing a YPG soldier' it responded to fire killing three protesters. Three other people were killed in 'unclear circumstances', and 50 supporters of the KNC-affiliated Yekiti party were arbitrarily detained (Human Rights Watch 2014, pp. 44–51), destroying any remaining trust (E2), transforming the KNC's perception of the PYD from an untrustworthy political rival into an existential threat and providing the PYD with a precedent for unilateral control. Even as Barzani-sponsored meetings continued, calling for 'national unity' (ANF News 2013a), the reality on the ground had fundamentally shifted. The PYD also came to perceive the KNC as an existential threat: attacks from ISIS and Syrian opposition-aligned Al-Nusra Front increased throughout 2013. The YPG accused 'some collaborative Kurdish brigades' of fighting alongside them, framing the KNC as complicit in these attacks (ANF News 2013c). For the PYD, this confirmed that any group aligned with the Turkish-backed opposition, including the KNC, could not be trusted with a role in security. As one former Turkish-backed commander recounted, seemingly Ankara ordered to 'Stop [fighting the regime], fight the YPG instead' (Holmes 2024, pp. 65–66). This narrative was articulated at the highest levels, with senior TEV-DEM leader Îlham Ehmed accusing the KNC of having withdrawn from the Kurdish Supreme Council to engage with the Syrian rebels and provide political cover to 'eliminate YPG forces' (ANF News 2013d). This perspective was reinforced by pro-PYD analyses defending the PYD's 'social revolution' against the KNC's elite-driven, foreign-backed, illegitimate political project (Dicle 2013). Tensions escalated, with several security incidents erupting in 2013 and prompting the KNC to withdraw from the DBK (Al-Ghazi 2021). In November 2013, the TEV-DEM announced an interim administration for the cantons that officially omitted references to 'Kurdistan' to align with the PYD's multi-ethnic 'Rojava Revolution' narrative (McGee 2022, p. 392), effectively superseding Erbil's joint-governance vision (Reuters 2013). PYD leaders claimed that the decision had the KNC's consent (ANF News 2013b), and framed this decision as a moral imperative legitimised by the 'resistance of the YPG forces' and a 'promise we made to our people', stating that KNC participation was desirable but ultimately non-essential (Yeni Özgür Politika 2013). According to Bachar, this decision was presented as a *fait accompli*: 'we have created the Autonomous Administration, you come and unite with us'. Our answer was No'.²⁹ This dynamic was not one sided; as the KNC responded by drafting its own constitution for a federal 'Syrian Kurdistan', reinforcing the programmatic divide (Al-Kati 2019, p. 53).

In December 2013, in preparation for the Geneva II talks, Barzani called for the Erbil II conference to join the talks as a united Kurdish front. The two sides agreed on several points, including KNC participation in Geneva II under a shared vision, ceasing media provocations, and creating committees to release detainees and investigate the Amude events. However, no agreement was reached on the administration of Kurdish regions or security issues, with the PYD maintaining its control (Asharq al-Awsat 2013). Salih Muslim called the talks 'positive', framing the 'revival' of the Supreme Council as a crucial step for presenting a united Kurdish front (ANF News 2013e). However, the PKK's high command (KCK), immediately declared that the goal of talks was to 'strengthen the interim administration', the very unilateral project that had made the joint council obsolete (ANF News 2013f). A senior PYD negotiator laid down the non-negotiable terms: the PYD's governance project was the only one on the table, and the YPG was 'not up for debate' as it was a 'national establishment' (ANF News 2013g). Thus, both sides entered the talks with incompatible goals: the KNC sought to co-design a new system, while the PYD sought to have the KNC ratify its existing one. External pressure (E3) could force the meeting, but it could not bridge this fundamental disagreement on the purpose of the negotiation itself. This process culminated on 29 January 2014 with the adoption of the Charter of the Social

Contract, the foundational document of the PYD-led administration (Peace in Kurdistan Campaign 2014). Its unilateral adoption marked a definitive defection from the Erbil framework, formalising the PYD's governance project without the jointly designed bodies it had envisaged. More than a political act, it institutionalised the PKK's revolutionary blueprint, a fact acknowledged by all parties. For the PYD, it was the fulfilment of its programme of grassroots democracy, with people 'administrating themselves . . . deciding for themselves'.³⁰ Allies shared this view. For the Syriac Union Party, the charter was a historic achievement, 'the most important document in Syrian history granting the rights of the Syriac people'.³¹ To this coalition, the Social Contract was a successful, inclusive, and legitimate political foundation. For the KNC, the Social Contract was a hostile and illegitimate imposition dictated by the PKK. Leaders framed it not as political rivalry but as a cultural war for the soul of the Kurdish nation, portraying the PYD's project as an assault on Kurdish customs, religion and family life. Mahmud Arbo expressed this critique bluntly: 'The PKK and the PYD do not create a community. They have come to destroy social customs and culture'. He accused the PYD of imposing a radical feminist agenda 'in a dictatorial way', of endorsing 'the transgender theory (homosexuality)', and of deliberately undermining the family: 'They want the family to no longer exist, because they think that if there is no more family they can recruit the children into the guerrilla'. He concluded by casting the PYD as 'enemies of the Kurds, [who] dress in Kurdish clothes but have a mercenary mentality'.³² Thus, while one coalition regarded the Social Contract as a charter of liberation, the other saw it as a declaration of cultural war, evidence of a programmatic incompatibility so profound that co-governance was not merely strategically difficult but conceptually impossible.

Episode 4 — ISIS Shock and the Duhok Agreement: Forced Convergence (Late-2014)

In mid-2014, ISIS launched a rapid multi-front offensive, seizing major Iraqi and Syrian cities and declaring a Caliphate (Wilson Center 2019). The October assault on Kurdish-held Kobani created an existential threat to Kurdish territories and forced a temporary convergence between the PYD and KNC engineered by a new external sponsor, the United States. By late 2014, Washington's 'train and equip' programme for vetted rebels had collapsed amid defections and surrenders to Jabhat al-Nusra, leaving it without a partner against ISIS (Knights and van Wilgenburg 2021, p. 98). Policymakers now regarded the YPG as the only 'pragmatic' option (Knights and van Wilgenburg 2021, pp. 40–41). For the PYD, the Kobani siege was both an existential and legitimacy crisis: to overcome Turkish objections (Knights and van Wilgenburg 2021, p. 40) to direct U.S. military support, it needed the cover of a pan-Kurdish front. This urgency spurred intensive third-party brokerage (E3). These conditions brought the PYD and KNC to the table for a pact explicitly 'brokered by the United States in Duhok' (Knights and van Wilgenburg 2021, p. 44). The U.S.-brokered Duhok Agreement was thus less a Kurdish bargain than an instrument of American counter-terrorism policy, designed to provide the political cover necessary for military action. As a result, on 20 October 2014, Washington conducted emergency airdrops to the YPG, while Ankara, in a deal with the KRG, allowed Iraqi peshmerga to cross Turkish territory to reinforce the town (The Guardian 2014a).

The agreement³³ itself acknowledged the extraordinary 'political and regional circumstances . . . and the humanitarian conditions' arising from the conflict, particularly 'in the areas controlled by ISIS' (Duhok Agreement 2014). To enforce trust and cooperation between the parties, the pact created a consensus-based 30-member Kurdish Political Authority, apportioned 40/ 40/20 (TEV-DEM/KNC/allied parties), to 'serve as the body responsible for setting strategies and general policies for the Kurds and unifying the Kurdish stance on all matters'. The agreement endorsed the Autonomous Administration and the Social Contract as a 'young experience that requires support, development, and modification'. Concerning defence, the agreement recognised 'defensive capabilities and the great sacrifices made by the YPG' but it emphasised that 'the duty of protection and defence of Rojava Kurdistan . . . falls on the shoulders of all its sons'. To this end, it proposed the formation of a specialised committee, in coordination with the YPG leadership, to find ways for forces affiliated with the KNC to participate (Duhok Agreement 2014). Appendix B provides a detailed analysis of the agreement and its outcomes.

The KNC understood this as a pact for genuine co-governance, where the integration of its Peshmerga was contingent on a system in which 'power [was] shared'.³⁴ The PYD, however, interpreted the new

Kurdish Political Authority as a ‘consultative’ body (Özgür Gündem 2014) that the KNC could join to ‘participate in the administration’ it had already established (ANF News 2014). Moreover, the PYD did not consider the security clauses as binding, stating that had the KNC proposed altering the YPG’s command, ‘we would have walked out of the meeting’ (Özgür Gündem 2014). This demonstrates a persistent interpretive gap (E1) where the dominant actor interpreted the pact as a means to preserve, not share, its core institutional gains. On the other hand, the U.S. itself did not force the KNC Roj Peshmerga’s integration, dismissed as ‘theoretical’ forces unprepared for combat (Knights and van Wilgenburg 2021, pp. 40–41). In practice, the specific, tactical, and externally enforced military clauses succeeded: following the agreement, KRG peshmerga convoys with heavy weapons joined the defence of Kobani on the 31st of October, and ground conditions began to shift in favour of the Kurdish defenders (The Guardian 2014b). This battlefield coordination was the product of third-party enforcement (E3), not inter-group trust. U.S. and KRG pressure, together with the existential threat from ISIS, could not overcome the PYD’s non-negotiable veto on integrating external Kurdish forces. Even while the battle for Kobani was undecided, YPG spokesman Redur Xelil insisted that although any Kurdish fighter had ‘the right to join YPG ranks . . . to allow other Kurdish military units in Rojava is dangerous because of military rivalry and tensions could lead to more destruction than good’ (Rudaw 2014). This refusal drew directly on the historical analogy of the 1990s KDP – PUK civil war in Iraqi Kurdistan, blamed on the coexistence of two party-affiliated armies (Knights and van Wilgenburg 2021, p. 41). A senior commander later made the logic explicit: ‘It was impossible to have two armies . . . multiple military forces could not agree and were fighting each other all the time’ (Knights and van Wilgenburg 2021, p. 99). This framing transformed security integration from a negotiable point into an existential red line, rendering the commitment problem structurally insoluble. The same dynamic applied to political clauses.

The agreement stipulated elections within a year and KNC participation in administration within two to three months, yet none were implemented, with each side blaming the other (Rudaw 2021). From the KNC perspective, ‘We talked about unifying the armed forces . . . but were they implemented? No’, one leader recalled, adding they would only have accepted Peshmerga integration if ‘power [was] shared’.³⁵ From the PYD perspective, the KNC ‘sabotaged the negotiations by aligning with foreign pressures’.³⁶ Thus, despite its ambitious goals, the Duhok Agreement quickly unravelled. Internal KNC disputes over seat allocation within the Political Authority stalled its formation (Al-Ghazi 2021). Tensions deepened in November 2014 when the Autonomous Administration unilaterally introduced mandatory conscription, and in February 2015 it held local elections without KNC participation. These moves eroded the remaining trust and precipitated the agreement’s collapse (Al-Ghazi 2021). The Duhok episode thus illustrates the limits of external sponsorship: while U.S. and KRG coordination enabled short-term battlefield cooperation at Kobani, it could not substitute for the trust necessary to enforce durable institutions in the face of deep programmatic incompatibility (E3).

After the Duhok framework collapsed, the United States shifted to institutionalising the PYD’s alliance model, which had proved effective on the battlefield. In October 2015 it backed the creation of the Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF), a multi-ethnic umbrella uniting the YPG/YPJ with Arab, Syriac, and other local militias (Knights and van Wilgenburg 2021, p. 99). Salih Muslim described the model as bottom-up integration: local military and civil councils were formed in all towns that would be liberated from ISIS, which would then ‘coordinate with’ the SDF.³⁷ This strategy was effective in incorporating Arab-majority areas (Holmes 2024, p. 63) but programmatically unacceptable to the KNC. For them, it was not a tactical dispute but a rejection of the society the PYD envisioned and the legitimacy of its non-Kurdish allies. Mahmud Arbo voiced this distrust sharply: ‘In general, all Arabs are against the Kurds, but some for convenience support the Kurds. They do it for the money . . . When ISIS came, they became ISIS . . . when SDF came, they are all with SDF’.³⁸ Following the collapse of the Duhok framework, the SDF’s rapid expansion thus marked the definitive triumph of the PYD’s programme. It institutionalised a multi-ethnic vision the KNC saw as betrayal, cemented PYD military hegemony, and foreclosed any prospect of a Kurdish front on the KNC’s ethno-nationalist terms. In the following years, the KNC moved closer to the SNC, supporting Turkey’s subsequent military operations against the PYD/YPG (Middle East Institute 2019, pp. 12–16).

Assessing Alternative Explanations

Competing structural, identity and sponsor-centric explanations account for parts of the PYD – KNC rivalry, but do not explain why repeated bargains collapsed despite high material incentives and external pressure. Structural-materialist accounts offer one lens. Schwab's (2023) constraint-based model explains the timing of the Duhok talks, which coincided with extreme threat from ISIS. Martin C Steinwand and Nils W Metternich's (2022) focus on military synergies would also predict a 'tacit coalition' based on co-location and a shared enemy. Yet neither explains why negotiations failed to produce a durable, institutionalised pact. Material incentives can bring rivals to the table, but only programmatic compatibility determines whether they can sign and sustain a meaningful deal. Theories of co-ethnic competition likewise have explanatory power. Justin Conrad et al. (2021) correctly predict the baseline rivalry of co-ethnics, such as the PYD and KNC. The puzzle, however, is not the existence of rivalry but the inability to sustain even tactical pacts. Nor was this conflict a case of intra-programmatic outbidding over authenticity, as Mohammad Ayatollahi Tabaar (2025) theorises. It was a collision between two mutually exclusive political programmes. By mid-2015 this divide had hardened into a manichaeian worldview: the YPG branded the KNC's main ally, the SNC, a 'collaborator and partner-in-crime of the ISIS gangs', and by extension framed the KNC as tainted by association with an existential enemy (ANF News 2015). Such a cleavage cannot be reduced to rivalry alone. The argument also refines models of external influence. A simple proxy-war framing is insufficient. The KDP – PKK rivalry provides the essential backdrop, but it does not capture the mechanisms of failure on the ground, which concerned not only patronal competition but a clash between two models of alliance-building. The KNC, bound to its patron's ethno-nationalist blueprint, pursued a rigid diplomatic strategy with partners who rejected its core goals. The PYD, by contrast, used its multi-ethnic confederalism to construct coalitions through programmatic coincidence, an alignment with Syrian actors, such as the Syriac Union Party, whose leader Sanharip Barsom endorsed it as 'the best suited' project for Syrians and Christians.³⁹ Finally, the findings challenge sponsor-centric theories that view external leverage as a solution to commitment problems (Popovic 2018). The U.S.-brokered Duhok Agreement illustrates why such interventions fail in the face of programmatic incompatibility. Washington acted not as a neutral arbiter but as a transactional sponsor whose overriding goal was defeating ISIS (Knights and van Wilgenburg 2021, p. 41). Its support for the PYD was a marriage of 'expediency', with little interest in or leverage over the group's political programme (Knights and van Wilgenburg 2021, p. 38). A sponsor that prioritises its own strategic goals cannot resolve the foundational disputes of its proxies. At best, it can enforce temporary battlefield coordination; it cannot build the political trust required for durable settlement when ideological incompatibilities remain unresolved. The framework advanced here therefore incorporates material and external factors while showing that programmatic incompatibility acts as the binding constraint that renders these material incentives insufficient.

Conclusion

The persistent failure of PYD – KNC cooperation in Syria resulted from programmatic ideological incompatibility. The PYD's vision of a decentralised, multi-ethnic confederalism was fundamentally irreconcilable with the KNC's goal of a traditional ethno-national federation. This chasm generated divergent interpretations of the conflict (E1), creating a low-trust environment that made the parties unwilling to accept enforceable commitments on security or power-sharing (E2) despite the intervention of foreign sponsors and mediators (E3). Consequently, even the intense transactional pressure of a superpower sponsor could produce temporary battlefield alignment, as seen in Kobani, but it could not build a shared political understanding. External pressure substituted for trust rather than creating it.

This research specifies how programmatic distance generates an intractable commitment problem by structuring the core dilemmas of rebel governance. It moves beyond treating ideology as a simple measure of affinity by examining its role in shaping institutional design and credible commitments. It also refines theories of external influence by distinguishing the causal roles of constitutive patrons and transactional sponsors. Constitutive patrons such as the PKK or KDP provide the non-negotiable

programmatic blueprints that create conflict red lines, whereas transactional sponsors such as the United States, driven by narrow geopolitical goals, can enforce only tactical compliance rather than sustained cooperation. The argument is not that ideology always dominates material interests, but that in cases of high programmatic incompatibility, it can filter interpretation and thin trust to the point that cooperation becomes impossible even under strong structural incentives.

Future research could extend this analysis. First, this article's qualitative approach could be complemented by a quantitative research agenda. This would require coding rebel groups' programmatic ideologies to capture the specific institutional content of their political blueprints (for instance, federal vs. unitary, ethno-national vs. civic) rather than simple left-right or secular-religious dichotomies. Such a dataset would allow for large-N testing of the hypothesis that higher programmatic incompatibility scores correlate with lower rates of durable alliance formation. Second, comparative case analysis could test the theory's scope conditions, including cases of moderate ideological incompatibility or those where a single powerful patron attempts to enforce cooperation between programmatically opposed groups. The mechanism should travel to cases where parties advance non-overlapping institutional design, at least one actor holds a red line over security or institutional design, and mediation is biased or sponsorship transactional. It should be weakest where a single patron can impose a common programme across clients. Finally, future work should explore ideological change dynamics to understand how and why these core blueprints might converge or diverge over the course of a long conflict.

These findings hold important implications. For scholars, they suggest the need to move beyond binary coding of ideology to measure the content of alliance clauses. For practitioners, the lesson is that declaratory unity is insufficient. Durable pacts require mediators, particularly external sponsors, to recognise the limits of transactional brokerage. Attempts to build security arrangements without first confronting foundational disagreements over the future political order are likely to produce agreements that collapse as soon as immediate pressures recede. Ultimately, this case demonstrates that without a shared, or at least compatible, design for political order, carefully sequenced agreements are likely to fail. External support can manage a conflict but cannot resolve a commitment problem rooted in two irreconcilable visions of the future.

Notes

1. Costantino Pischedda's (2018) 'window theory' models how shifts in the three-way balance of power between two rebel groups and the state alter incentives. A 'window of opportunity' opens for a stronger group to eliminate a weaker rival, while a 'window of vulnerability' can provoke a pre-emptive attack from the weaker party.
2. Gade et al. (2019) operationalise ideology by disaggregating it into three key dimensions: conflict framing, ideal polity and territorial aspiration. My theory adapts this approach by focusing on the institutional dimensions of the ideal polity.
3. Such programmatic commitments are found across diverse contexts. See, for example, the institutional projects of the ELN in Colombia (Arjona 2016), the internal strategies of the Naxalite movement in India (Suykens 2015), and the Islamic State, whose theological program dictated not only its military strategy but also its detailed systems of taxation (Revkin 2020, pp. 2, 6–9) and internal legal codes governing members' behaviour (Revkin and Wood 2021, pp. 26–30).
4. PKK refers to the Kurdistan Workers' Party (Partiya Karkerên Kurdistanê), a Kurdish militant and political organisation founded in Turkey in 1978. The PKK has historically advocated for Kurdish self-determination and engaged in armed conflict with the Turkish state. The PYD in Syria is often considered an offshoot or affiliate of the PKK, sharing ideological roots and organisational ties. However, the PYD maintains it operates independently.
5. KDP (Partiya Demokrat a Kurdistanê) is one of the two major ruling parties in the Kurdistan Region of Iraq (KRI). Founded in 1946 by Mustafa Barzani, the KDP has historically been a dominant force in Kurdish politics.
6. In-person interviews with KNC leaders were conducted in Kurdish with consecutive interpretation into Italian by a Kurdish – Italian bilingual interpreter; the PYD co-chair online interview was conducted in English; the SUP co-chair online interview in Arabic with interpretation into Italian. To mitigate language risk, a native speaker later checked samples of translated passages and confirmed accuracy. Quotations are lightly edited for clarity. Interpreters remain anonymous by agreement. Audio files and transcripts are securely stored and not publicly shareable due to consent terms. The author is an Italian political scientist (University of Milan PhD student at the time of fieldwork) with long-standing research on the Kurdish question in Europe and Turkey. The study does not claim competence in Arabic or Kurdish; interpreter-mediated access and post-hoc native checks were used to manage language risk. Access routes included academic introductions and organisational gatekeepers on both sides, generating asymmetric access (denser KNC bench; single PYD principal) that is treated as substantive context and mitigated through cross-source triangulation.

7. The author acknowledges the limitations inherent in the primary interview data, particularly its imbalanced composition and elite focus. Due to logistical constraints and access, the interview sample is weighted towards the KNC leadership, with the PYD's perspective primarily represented by a single co-chair and supplemented by an allied party leader. This asymmetry necessarily means that the reconstruction of the KNC's interpretive framework and decision-making process is rendered with greater granularity than that of the PYD. While the analysis documents PYD actions and public justifications through documentary evidence and secondary sources, the certainty with which this study can infer internal PYD motivations is correspondingly limited. The mitigation strategies employed were the systematic triangulation of all interview claims against contemporaneous agreements, official communiqués, and secondary reports, were therefore central to counteracting this potential bias and ensuring analytical rigour.
8. Kurdish majority areas are present near the Turkish border: the north of Jazira, Jarablus and Afrin. In all regions are also present substantial minorities. For instance, Kurds in the Jazira region lived alongside several numerically significant communities, including Arabs and Assyrians (Lowe 2014).
9. These disputes included conflicts over water rights to the Euphrates River and Syria's unresolved territorial claim to the Hatay province (Gunter 2014, p. 54).
10. The KNC at its foundation included: the Kurdish Democratic Party in Syria (al-Parti), the Kurdish Democratic National Party in Syria, the Kurdish Democratic Equality Party in Syria, the Kurdish Democratic Progressive Party in Syria, the Kurdish Democratic Unity Party in Syria (Yekiti), the Kurdish Yekiti Party in Syria, the Azadi Kurdish Party in Syria, the Syrian Democratic Kurdish Party, the Kurdish Left Party in Syria, Yekiti Kurdistanî, and the Kurdish Democratic Wifaq Party (Carnegie Middle East Center 2012).
11. Author's interview with Salih Muslim, Online, June 2023.
12. Author's interview with Ibrahim Biro, Erbil, January 2023.
13. Author's interview with Mahmod Arbo, Erbil, December 2022.
14. Author's interview with Mahmod Arbo, Erbil, December 2022.
15. Author's interview with Abdul Hakim Bachar, Erbil, December 2022.
16. Author's interview with Ibrahim Biro, Erbil, January 2023.
17. Author's interview with Salih Muslim, Online, June 2023.
18. Author's interview with Mahmod Arbo, Erbil, December 2022.
19. Author's interview with Salih Muslim, Online, June 2023.
20. Author's interview with Sanharip Barsom, Online, June 2023.
21. Author's interview with Abdul Hakim Bachar, Erbil, December 2022.
22. Author's interview with Mahmod Arbo, Erbil, December 2022.
23. Author's interview with Ibrahim Biro, Erbil, January 2023.
24. Author's interview with Abdul Hakim Bachar, Erbil, December 2022.
25. Author's interview with Abdul Hakim Bachar, Erbil, December 2022.
26. Author's interview with Mahmod Arbo, Erbil, December 2022.
27. Author's interview with Ibrahim Biro, Erbil, January 2023.
28. Author's interview with Salih Muslim, Online, June 2023.
29. Author's interview with Abdul Hakim Bachar, Erbil, December 2022.
30. Author's interview with Salih Muslim, Online, June 2023.
31. Author's interview with Sanharip Barsom, Online, June 2023.
32. Author's interview with Mahmod Arbo, Erbil, December 2022.
33. I received the Duhok agreement text (in Arabic, translated into English by a professional translator) from the KNC leadership.
34. Author's interview with Ibrahim Biro, Erbil, January 2023.
35. Author's interview with Abdul Hakim Bachar, Erbil, December 2022.
36. Author's interview with Salih Muslim, Online, June 2023.
37. Author's interview with Salih Muslim, Online, June 2023.
38. Author's interview with Mahmod Arbo, Erbil, December 2022.
39. Author's interview with Sanharip Barsom, Online, June 2023.

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Data Availability Statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available upon reasonable request. The data are not publicly available as they fall outside the scope of the consent provided.

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Appendices

Appendix A: Detailed Chronology of Events and Activation of Causal Mechanisms

Table A1. This table traces the key events in the PYD-KNC relationship, identifying the causal mechanism(s) activated at each stage and providing a brief analytical interpretation of the causal process.

Date(s)	Event	Mechanism(s) Activated	Analytical Interpretation: Causal Process
Episode 1: Early Positioning (2011–2012)			
Apr 7, 2011	Syria restores citizenship to many stateless Kurds.	M1	Contextual shift: regime offers an incentive that does not alter the parties' underlying programmatic preferences.
May 2011	'Initiative of the National Movement' announced.	M1	A superficial consensus on a rights agenda masks deep, divergent strategic readings of acceptable partners and sequencing.
Oct 26, 2011	Kurdish National Council (KNC) is formally established.	M1, M3	The KNC's program (federalism via SNC) is institutionalised under the direct Patronage of the KDP, creating a formal, incompatible alternative to the PYD's project.
Apr 2012	KNC revises charter, removing 'self-determination'.	M1, M3	Forced programmatic concession demonstrates the constraints imposed by the KNC's chosen strategic partner (SNC) and the influence of its Patron (KDP), which favoured the alliance.
Episode 2: Erbil Agreement (2012–2013)			
Jun 11, 2012	Hewlêr/Erbil I Agreement signed (Supreme Committee).	M2, M3	A formal pact is created under the auspices of the KDP acting as a Patron-Mediator. Its vague security clauses lack enforcement in a low-trust environment.
Nov 7, 2012	Hewlêr Declaration reaffirms pact with bylaws.	M2	The addition of timelines and bylaws without sanctions fails to solve the core commitment problem, showing the limits of formalisation without trust.
Jun 27–28, 2013	Amûdê killings/detentions of anti-PYD protesters.	M2	A violent breach of confidence-building clauses by the dominant actor (PYD) signals the pact's unenforceability and causes irreversible trust erosion.
Jul 16 & 21, 2013	Reports emerge that the Supreme Committee has failed.	M2, M3	The institutional failure becomes public. The Patron-Mediator (KRG) can convene parties but cannot compel compliance with the pact's core terms. (Continued)
Sep 2013	YPG accuses 'collaborative Kurdish brigades' of aiding jihadists.	M1, M3	The interpretive gap is securitised; the PYD publicly frames KNC-aligned actors as collaborators, influenced by Turkey's role as a rival Patron to FSA groups.
Nov 12, 2013	TEV-DEM unilaterally declares interim administration.	M1, M2	The PYD formally defects from the joint-design principle, enacting its 'governance-first' sequencing and superseding the Erbil framework.
Dec 10, 2013	'Erbil II' meeting establishes ad hoc committees.	M2, M3	Remedial, issue-specific fixes are attempted under the Patron-Mediator's guidance, but they substitute for, rather than repair, the absent enforcement architecture.
Jan 29, 2014	PYD-led coalition adopts the Charter of the Social Contract.	M1, M2	Unilateral institutionalisation deepens programmatic asymmetry, crystallising the PYD's 'ideal polity' and directly implementing its Patron's (PKK) blueprint.
Episode 4: Duhok Agreement (2014–2015)			
Oct 20, 2014	U.S. conducts emergency airdrops to YPG in Kobani.	M3	The U.S. acts as a Transactional Sponsor, providing tactical support to achieve a limited goal (anti-ISIS), creating a narrow window for cooperation.
Oct 20–23, 2014	Turkey approves KRG peshmerga transit to Kobani.	M3	Third-party brokerage by the Sponsor (U.S.) and Patron-Mediator (KRG) aligns logistics for a specific military task but does not harmonise political programs.
Oct 22–26, 2014	Duhok Agreement is negotiated and signed.	M2, M3	A new pact is brokered by the U.S. (Sponsor) and KRG (Patron-Mediator). Its mixed design reflects the tension between tactical needs and political incompatibility.
Oct 31 - Nov 1, 2014	First KRG peshmerga convoy enters Kobani.	M3	The specific, crisis-salient military clause is implemented under intense pressure from the Transactional Sponsor, a classic case of enforced compliance substituting for trust.
Nov 2014	YPG command states KNC forces must be absorbed, not allied.	M1, M2, M3	The PYD's non-negotiable red line is articulated, explicitly referencing its Patron's (PKK) historical lesson from the 1990s Iraqi Kurdish civil war. This is the clearest evidence of constitutive ideology overriding sponsor pressure.
Nov 2014	AANES enacts mandatory conscription law.	M2	A unilateral policy decision contradicts the Duhok pact's 'amend-first' principle, violating the agreed sequencing and eroding trust.

Date(s)	Event	Mechanism(s) Activated	Analytical Interpretation: Causal Process
Feb 2015	AANES holds local elections without KNC consensus.	M2	The failure of the joint Political Authority leads to a reversion to unilateral control, demonstrating the complete collapse of the pact's institutional clauses.
Post-2015	U.S. declines KNC requests to enforce Duhok Agreement.	M3	The Transactional Sponsor reverts to its primary geopolitical interest (anti-ISIS partnership with PYD), confirming its influence was contingent and not aimed at building a durable political settlement.

Appendix B: Erbil/Hewler and Duhok Agreement Clauses and Observed Outcome

Table B1. This table summarises the Erbil and Duhok agreement clauses, the observed outcome and how the process tracing verified the parties' compliance/non-compliance.

Agreement (date)	Section/Area	Clause/Requirement	Decision Rule/Mechanism	Timeline Specified	Observed Outcome (2012–2015)	How to verify (documents or events to check)
Erbil/Hewlêr I Minutes (11 Jun 2012)	Political Coordination	Create joint 'Supreme Committee' to coordinate political/ diplomatic work and develop a unified objective	Not specified	None	Formed briefly (then re-articulated as the 'High Kurdish Committee' later in 2012), but stalled; no durable joint leadership beyond 2013	formal announcement of Supreme/ High Kurdish Committee; meeting minutes; later reports noting paralysis/cessation (mid-2013).
Erbil/Hewlêr I Minutes (11 Jun 2012)	Field Coordination	Form a Supreme Organizational Committee and regional sub-committees	Not specified	None	No evidence of a sustained, functioning organisational committee beyond initial announcements	named members; schedules; signed joint operational orders; persistent minutes after 2012.
Erbil/Hewlêr I Minutes (11 Jun 2012)	Media/De-escalation	Cease propaganda/media attacks	Not specified	Immediate/ongoing	Violated by both sides within weeks	party press releases & partisan outlets resuming accusations (late 2012–early 2013).
Erbil/Hewlêr I Minutes (11 Jun 2012)	Security (Force Posture)	Abolish all armed presence in Kurdish regions; create joint, unarmed protection committees	Not specified	Immediate/ongoing	Missed. YPG remained the dominant armed actor; no joint unarmed protection regime; 2013 incidents (e.g., Amûdê) showed coercive posture	any disarmament orders; evidence of unarmed joint patrols; NGO/ press incident logs in 2013.
Erbil/Hewlêr I Minutes (11 Jun 2012)	Social Conflict Resolution	Create joint mediation/ conciliation committees	Not specified	None	No documented, standing joint mediation bodies functioning across cantons	rosters; cases mediated jointly; decisions issued in both parties' names.
Hewlêr Declaration (7 Nov 2012)	Political Coordination	Establish a High Kurdish Committee (HKC) as umbrella	Consensus	Immediate	Paper commitment only; mechanisms under-specified; practical authority did not consolidate	HKC bylaws/mandate; calls for meetings; outputs beyond late-2012.
Hewlêr Declaration (7 Nov 2012)	Institutional Design	Parity principle in structuring committees; decisions by consensus; ban on violence	Consensus	Immediate	Consensus on paper; practice showed paralysis; 2013 confrontations escalated	membership lists showing parity; minutes recording consensus procedures; incident records.
Hewlêr Declaration (7 Nov 2012)	Local Execution	Establish three expert committees (political, services, security)	Noted in text	Within 2 weeks	Deadline missed. No evidence all three committees were stood up within two weeks	dated decrees establishing all three by late Nov 2012; outputs in Dec 2012–Jan 2013.
Hewlêr Declaration (7 Nov 2012)	Media/De-escalation	Suspend media campaigns	—	Immediate/ongoing	Violated	partisan outlets or official statements resuming allegations (late 2012–early 2013).
Hewlêr Declaration (7 Nov 2012)	Security/Tensions	Ban violence; abolish armed manifestations	—	Immediate/ongoing	Violated. 2013 confrontations culminated in Amûdê killings/ detentions	NGO/press documentation (mid-2013); any joint investigation records.
Hewlêr Declaration (7 Nov 2012)	Operationalisation	Adopt bylaws/working procedures for HKC	Consensus	Near-term	Bylaws referenced; enforcement architecture ineffective	appended bylaws text; any procedures actually used in 2012–2013.
Hewlêr Declaration (7 Nov 2012)	Implementation Schedule	Form committees and begin work	—	Within 2 weeks	Missed	dated formation notices (by late Nov 2012); absence implies deadline failure.
Duhok Agreement (22 Oct 2014)	Kurdish Political Authority (KPA)	Create 30-member KPA; decisions by consensus, binding on all components	Consensus; binding	Implement within 2 months	Not constituted. Seat-allocation disputes and rapid slippage ended the effort	formal KPA roll-out; membership list; first-meeting minutes; any binding KPA decisions.
Duhok Agreement (22 Oct 2014)	Kurdish Political Authority (KPA)	Seat allocation 40/40/20 (TEV-DEM/KNC/others); elections to fill the 20 per cent	Consensus	Within 2 months (implementation); within 1 year (elections)	Allocation never realised; the 20 per cent 'others' were never elected	roster reflecting 12–12–6 distribution; election protocol and results for the '20 per cent' block.
Duhok Agreement (22 Oct 2014)	Democratic Autonomous Administration	Amend Social Contract via a KPA-formed committee before elections	Committee formed by KPA	Before elections	Missed. No KPA-formed committee amended the Social Contract before elections; AANES proceeded unilaterally	committee formation decree; draft amendments; election decrees issued without prior amendment.
Duhok Agreement (22 Oct 2014)	Democratic Autonomous Administration	Expand the administration by consensus (political/ administrative unity)	Consensus	Within 2 months	Missed. No consensus-based expansion including ENKS occurred within the window	appointments adding ENKS nominees; organisational charts pre/post (Nov – Dec 2014).
Duhok Agreement (22 Oct 2014)	Protection & Defence	Recognise YPG sacrifices; specialist committee with YPG to find modalities for ENKS-affiliated forces' participation	Committee with YPG leadership	Within 2 months (as part of implementation)	Partial and tactical. KRG Peshmerga transited to Kobani and coordinated fires/logistics; no enduring joint command or force integration	committee charter/minutes; records of Peshmerga convoys (late Oct – Nov 2014); YPG statements on non-integration of separate Kurdish units.
Duhok Agreement (22 Oct 2014)	Implementation Schedule	Implement agreed measures within two months; hold elections within a year	—	2 months / 1 year	Two-month deadline missed; only tactical cooperation advanced; joint election targets not met	dated actions by 2014–12-22; evidence limited to battlefield coordination around Kobani; later unilateral election steps.